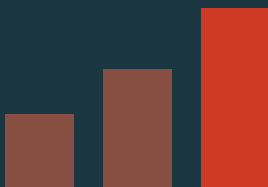


FREE GUIDE · FORTY TWO CAPITAL

The Ultimate Guide to Reading Your Credit Report

How to decode your CIBIL, Experian, Equifax and CRIF reports — and spot the errors that quietly block your loans.



1. Get all four reports — not just CIBIL

India has four RBI-licensed credit bureaus: TransUnion CIBIL, Experian, Equifax and CRIF High Mark. Every regulated lender reports your accounts to all four, but each bureau keeps its own copy of your data and computes its own score. An error can exist at one bureau and not the others — and you can't know in advance which report a lender will pull.

Each bureau must give you one free full report every year. Download all four before any major loan application. You are looking for the full report, not just the score.

Rule one: a clean CIBIL report does not mean a clean file. Check all four bureaus every time.

2. Verify your identity section first

Errors here cause the worst problems downstream. Check character by character:

- Name spelling, and any variants the bureau has merged
- PAN, date of birth, and address history
- Phone numbers and email addresses on file

A wrong PAN digit or a merged namesake is how a **mixed file** happens — someone else's loans appearing on your report. If any identity field is wrong, dispute it before anything else, because account-level corrections can fail while identity data is inconsistent.

3. Read the accounts section line by line

For every account (loan or card), verify five fields:

- **Ownership** — is this actually your account? Individual, joint, or guarantor status correct?
- **Status** — Open, Closed, Settled, or Written-off. 'Settled' where you repaid in full is a serious, disputable error.
- **Balance and sanctioned amount** — repaid loans must show zero outstanding.
- **Dates** — open date and, for closed accounts, the closure date actually recorded.
- **Duplicates** — the same loan listed twice (common after bank mergers and balance transfers) doubles your apparent debt.

The 'Settled' trap: 'Closed' means repaid in full; 'Settled' means the lender accepted less and wrote off the rest. Most banks treat 'Settled' like a default. If you repaid fully, dispute it. If an amount was genuinely waived, negotiate a zero-balance closure and a fresh NOC — in writing — then have the lender re-report as 'Closed'.

4. Decode the DPD grid

Each account shows a month-by-month payment history grid. The codes:

- **000 / STD** — paid on time (standard). This is what a healthy account looks like.
- **030 / 060 / 090...** — days past due that month. Anything above 000 hurts; 90+ is severe.
- **SMA** — special mention account (early stress marker).
- **SUB / DBT / LSS** — sub-standard, doubtful, loss. NPA classifications; severe damage.
- **XXX** — not reported that month (neutral).

Scan for DPD entries in months where you know you paid on time — mis-posted DPDs are among the most common and most disputable errors.

5. Audit the enquiries list

Every formal credit application triggers a hard enquiry, visible to other lenders. Several enquiries clustered within weeks flag you as 'credit hungry' and can cause rejections on their own.

Read your enquiry list for: applications you never made (possible identity misuse), commercial enquiries you didn't authorise, and marketplace apps that triggered multiple pulls from partner lenders. Unauthorised enquiries can be disputed.

Checking your own report is always a soft enquiry — it never affects your score.

6. The official dispute process

Disputing inaccurate information is your statutory right under the Credit Information Companies (Regulation) Act, 2005. The process:

1. Document the error precisely — account number, field, what it says vs. what is true.
2. Gather proof: statements, closure letters, NOCs, payment receipts.
3. File the dispute on the bureau's online portal — separately with each bureau showing the error.
4. Notify the reporting lender's grievance cell in parallel.
5. Track the RBI-mandated 30-day resolution window.
6. Escalate if needed: bureau escalation desk → lender nodal officer → RBI Ombudsman.

Corrections don't propagate. A fix accepted at CIBIL does not update Experian, Equifax or CRIF. File with every bureau where the error appears.

7. Quick self-audit checklist

- All four reports downloaded and dated this month
- Identity fields identical and correct on all four
- Every account recognised as yours
- No duplicates; closed loans show 'Closed' with zero balance
- No 'Settled' flags you didn't agree to

- DPD grids match your actual payment history
- Every enquiry recognised and authorised

If anything on this checklist fails, you have a disputable error — and fixing it is usually the fastest score improvement available.

Want us to do this for you?

Forty Two Capital audits all four bureau reports line by line, files professional disputes for every inaccuracy, and follows up until they're fixed. The audit is free and carries no obligation.

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